

Battle of Shimonoseki Strait
It was a challenge for both sides to negotiate the fast-flowing waters of the strait. At first the Taira had the advantage of the tide, but once they lost this, their cause was doomed.

KEY

MINAMOTO FLEET

40–45 galleys

TAIRA FLEET

40–45 galleys

HONSHU

Shimonoseki Strait

KYUSHU

INLAND SEA

Direction of ebb tides

The Minamoto galleys, which have the tides against them, are drawn up in line abreast across the entrance to the strait

The Taira divide their fleet into three squadrons and make use of the powerful tides to launch an attack on the stronger Minamoto fleet

1 CONTRASTING BATTLE LINES

The Minamoto draw up a defensive line across the entrance to the Shimonoseki Strait. The Taira, who plan one last, desperate action to escape their pursuers, split their fleet into three to launch an attack, making use of the favorable tide.

HONSHU

Shimonoseki Strait

KYUSHU

INLAND SEA

The Minamoto maintain their line, but the Taira start to outflank them

The battle begins with exchanges of arrows at long range

The Taira advance in three squadrons, hoping to outflank the Minamoto both on their left and their right

2 THE TAIRA HOLD THEIR OWN

The Taira attack goes well as they hit the enemy line on both its flanks and in the center, raining down arrows on the Minamoto ships. As battle is joined more closely, the Taira fight bravely and nobody can predict the outcome.